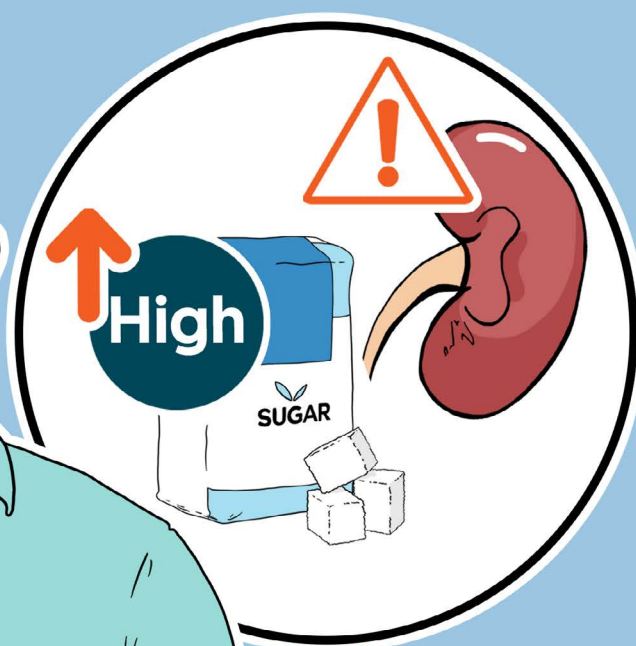
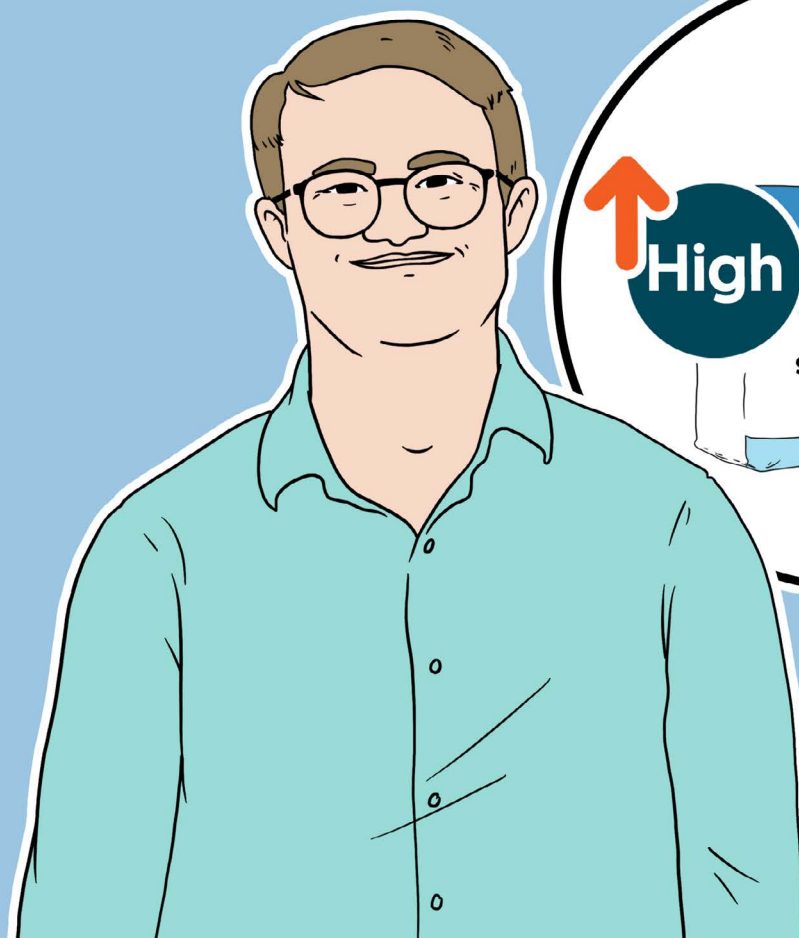


Diabetes and chronic kidney disease (CKD)

Information booklet



Supported by

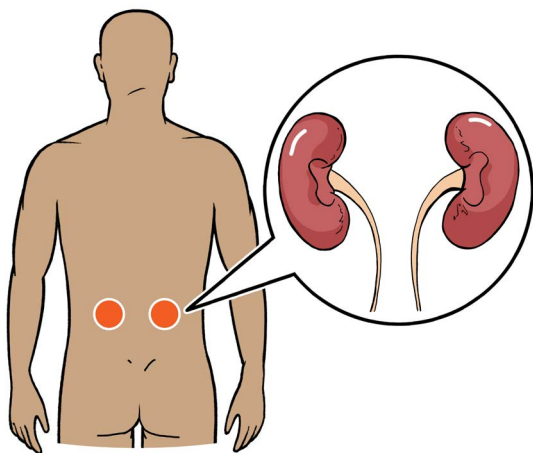
DiABETES UK
KNOW DIABETES. FIGHT DIABETES.

 **UKKA**
UK Kidney Association

 **Kidney
Care UK**

Easy read

Kidneys

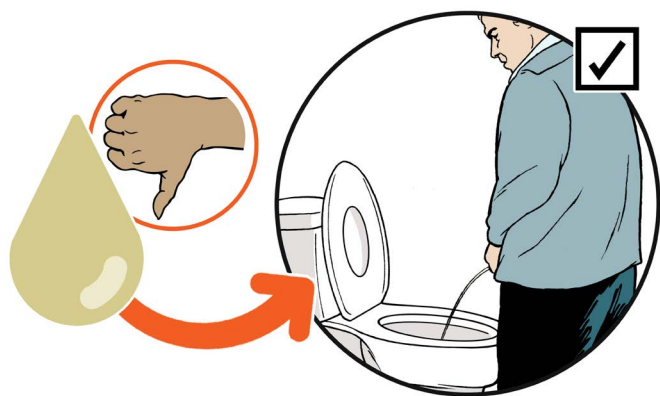


Most people have 2 **kidneys**. Your kidneys are in your lower back under the bottom rib. They are about the size of your fist and are shaped like kidney beans.

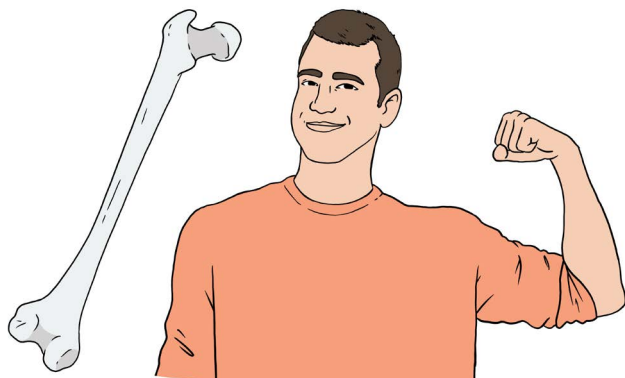


Your kidneys do lots of important jobs to keep you healthy, like:

- cleaning your blood

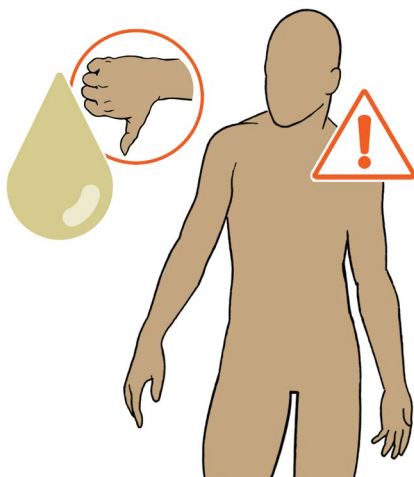
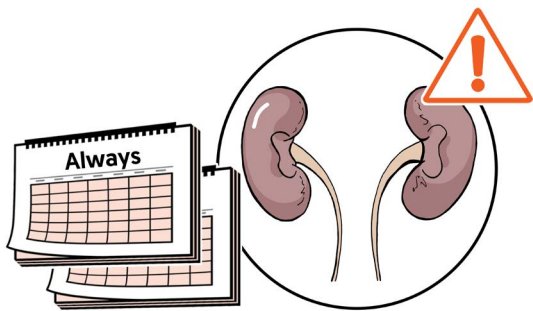
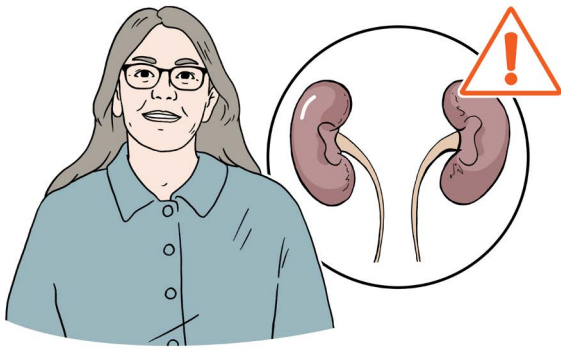


- getting rid of waste from your body in your wee



- keeping your bones strong.

Chronic kidney disease (CKD)



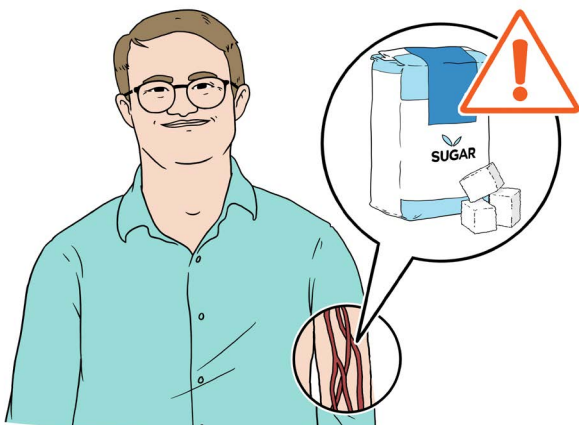
Chronic kidney disease (CKD)

means that your kidneys do not work as well as they should.

Chronic means that it is a long term illness and will last for the rest of your life.

If you have CKD then your kidneys can not get rid of waste in your body properly. This means that waste can build up in your body.

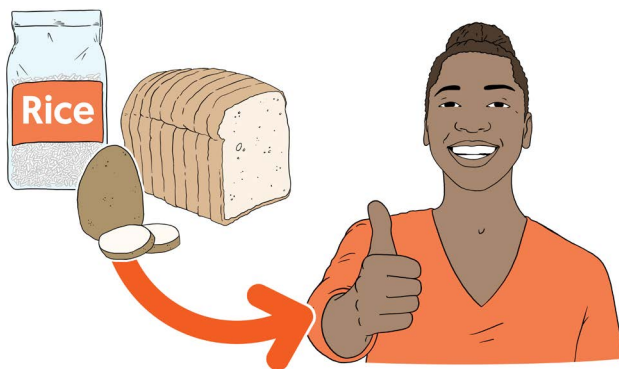
Diabetes



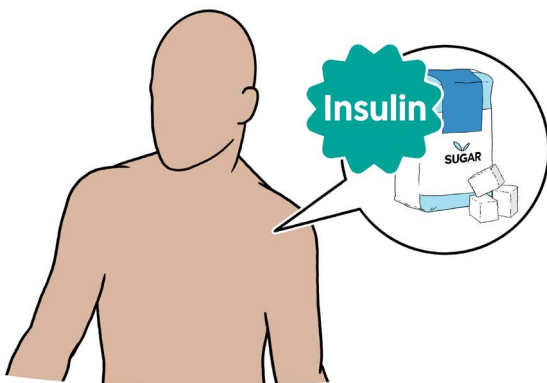
Diabetes is a serious condition that means there is too much sugar in your blood. Sugar can also be called **glucose**.



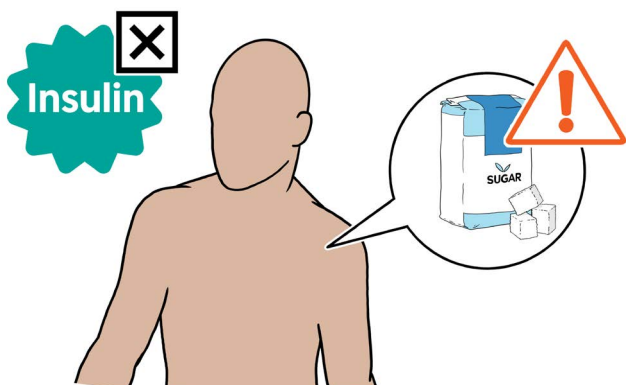
Sugar in your blood comes from food and drinks that have **carbohydrates** in them like rice, potatoes, bread, fruit, milk, cakes, chocolate and sugary drinks.



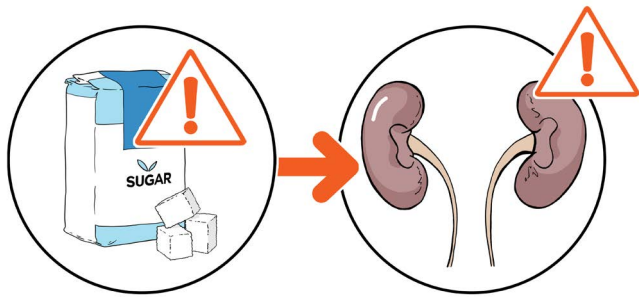
Carbohydrates give your body lots of energy. They are part of a healthy, balanced diet.



Your body normally makes a hormone called **insulin** that helps you turn sugar into energy.



If you have diabetes, your insulin is not working properly or your body does not make enough insulin. Sugar can then build up in your blood.



Having too much sugar in your blood can damage the kidneys and cause CKD.

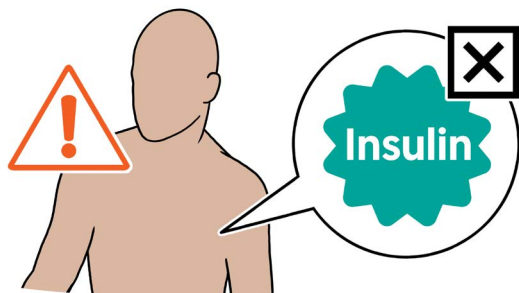
Types of diabetes



There are 2 main types of diabetes:

Type 1 diabetes

This is the most common type of diabetes in children but it can start at any age.



If you have type 1 diabetes, you can not make any insulin because your body attacks the cells that normally make it.

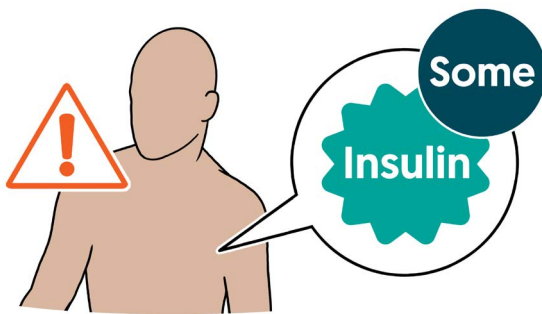


Type 2 diabetes

This usually happens in people over 40 years old but is becoming more common in younger people.

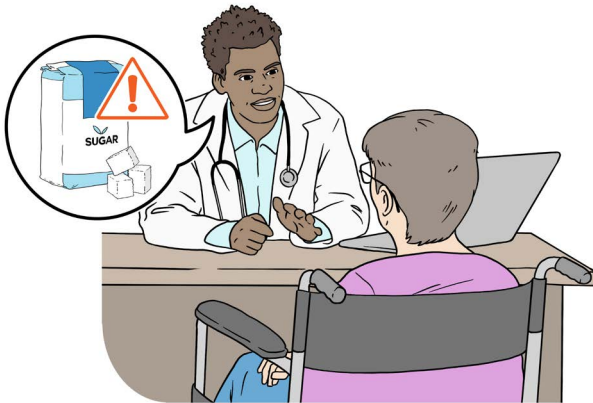


You are more likely have type 2 diabetes if you are Black or South Asian.

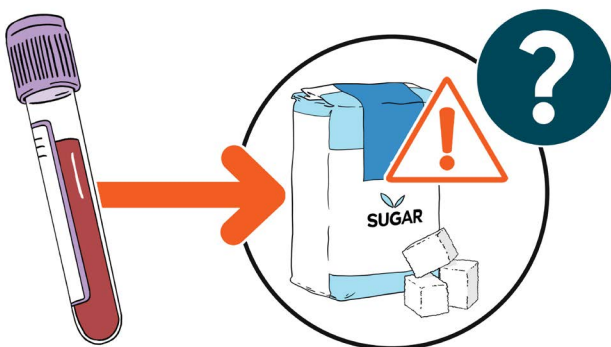


If you have type 2 diabetes the insulin your body makes might not work well enough or you might not make enough to keep you healthy.

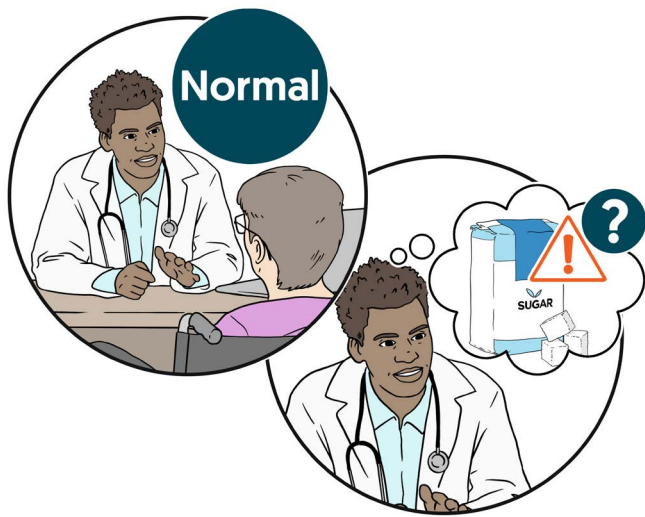
How is diabetes diagnosed?



Being **diagnosed** means when the doctor found out that you had diabetes.

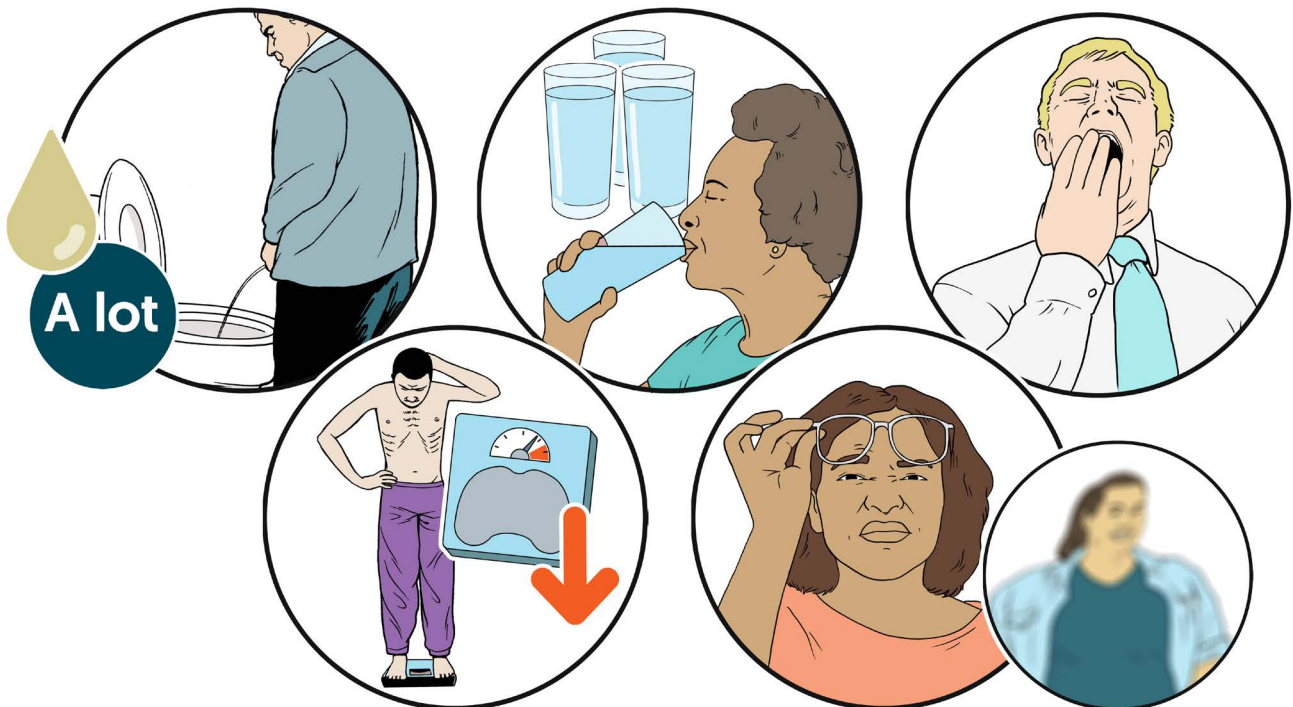


Diabetes is normally diagnosed with a blood test that checks how much sugar is in your blood.



You may have these tests as part of a normal check up with your doctor, or because your doctor thinks you may have diabetes.

What are the symptoms of diabetes?

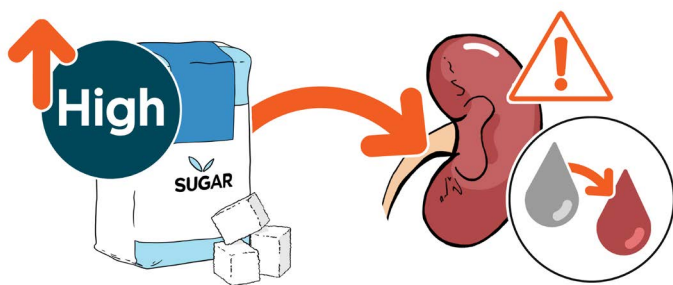


Symptoms are signs in your body that something is wrong.

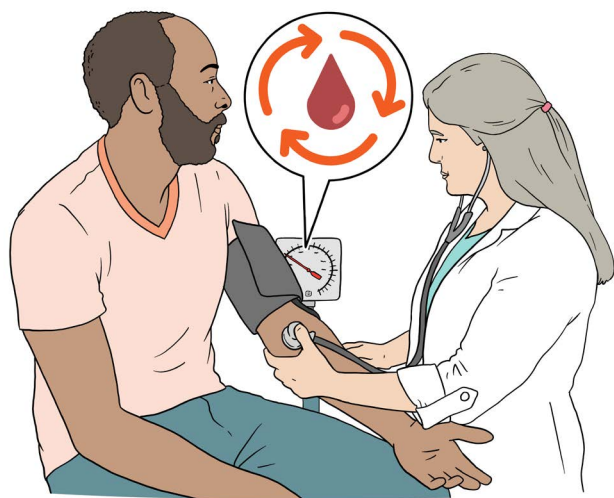
Possible symptoms of diabetes include:

- Having to go to the toilet to wee a lot
- Being very thirsty
- Feeling tired
- Losing weight without trying to
- Blurred vision

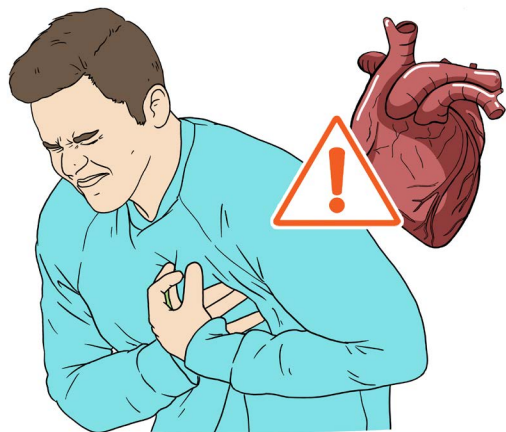
How will diabetes affect my kidneys?



Having too much sugar in your blood makes it thicker and stickier. This makes it harder for your kidneys to clean your blood. This can damage your kidneys.



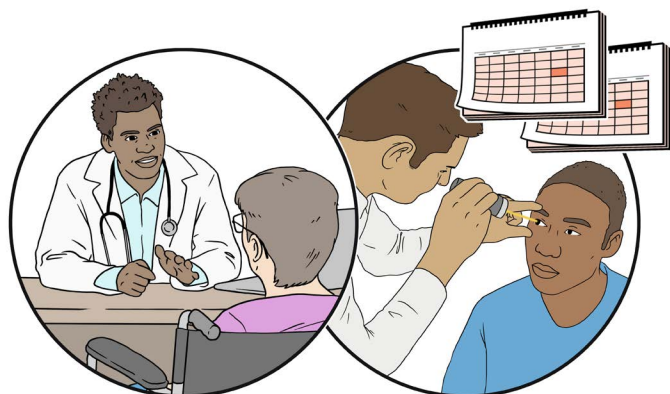
Both diabetes and kidney disease can cause high **blood pressure**. **Blood pressure** measures how strongly your blood is being pumped around your body.



High blood pressure increases the risk of heart attacks and strokes, as well as damaging the kidneys.



Foot and eye problems are also common for people with diabetes and kidney disease.

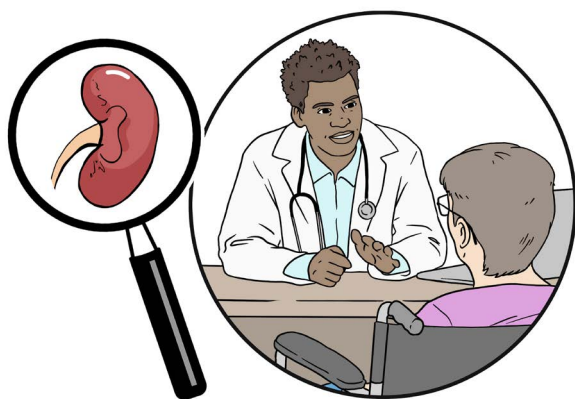


Regular checks with your GP and eye tests called **diabetic eye screenings**, will help to spot any problems early on so they can be treated.

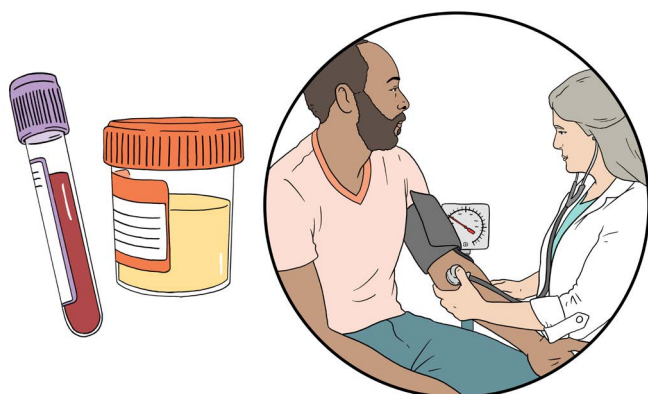
How will my kidneys be monitored if I have diabetes?



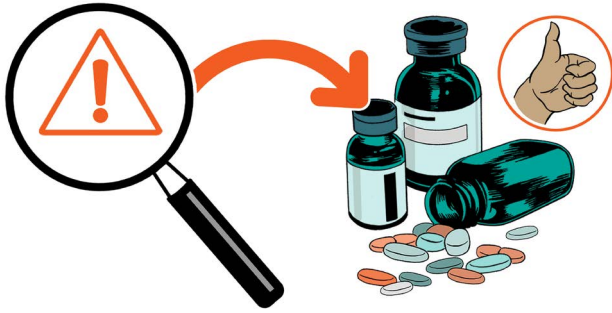
Diabetes is a life long condition that needs regular health checks.



Your kidney health will be checked by your GP during your regular diabetes appointments.



Your doctor will test your blood, wee, and blood pressure to check for any signs of kidney disease. When wee is tested it is called a **urine test**.

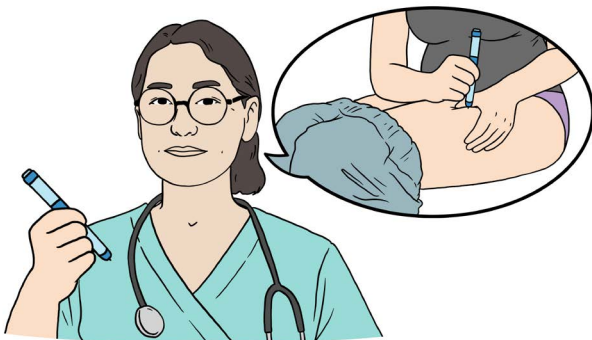


This will help your doctor to find and treat any problems early, before more serious damage can happen.

How is type 1 diabetes treated?



Type 1 diabetes is treated by daily insulin injections or an **insulin pump**. An **insulin pump** is a small machine that gives you insulin throughout the day and night.



You will be shown how to do these injections yourself at home.

How is type 2 diabetes treated?



Treatments for type 2 diabetes include eating a healthy balanced diet, moving more and trying to lose weight if you need to.

How is type 2 diabetes and kidney disease treated?



Most people with type 2 diabetes and kidney disease will be offered medication.

These include:

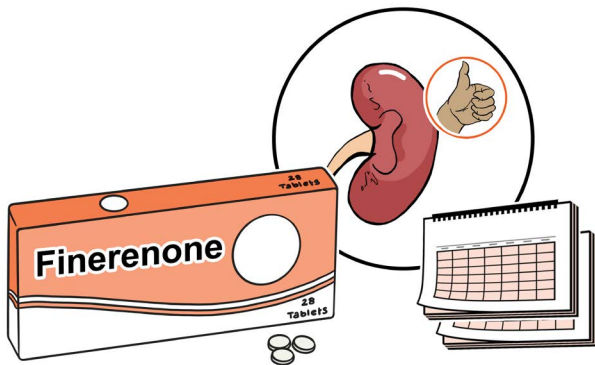
- **SGLT2 inhibitors**

These medications remove extra glucose from your body in your urine.



- **Finerenone**

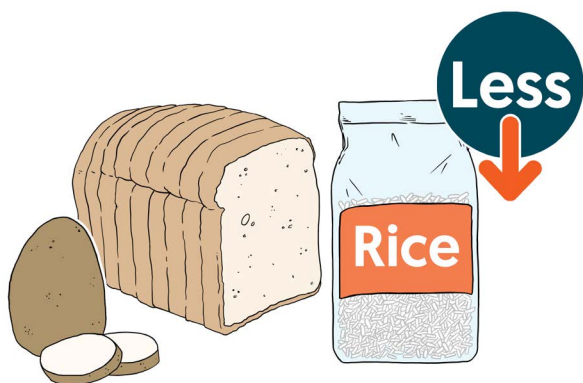
This medication can help to keep your kidneys working for longer.



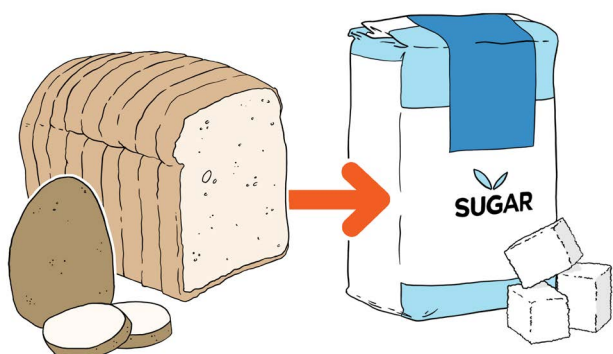
Do I need to eat a special diet if I have diabetes and CKD?



It is good for everyone to eat a balanced diet with more fruit and vegetables, and less sugary food and drink. You can get help with this from your healthcare team.



If you have diabetes, you may need to eat less carbohydrates like white rice, potatoes or white bread



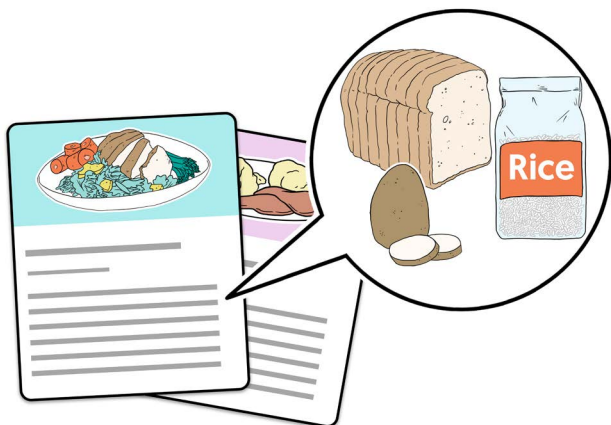
This is because carbohydrates break down into sugar in your stomach. The sugar then goes into your blood.



If you have type 1 diabetes you usually change the amount of insulin you inject at mealtimes based on how many carbohydrates you eat.

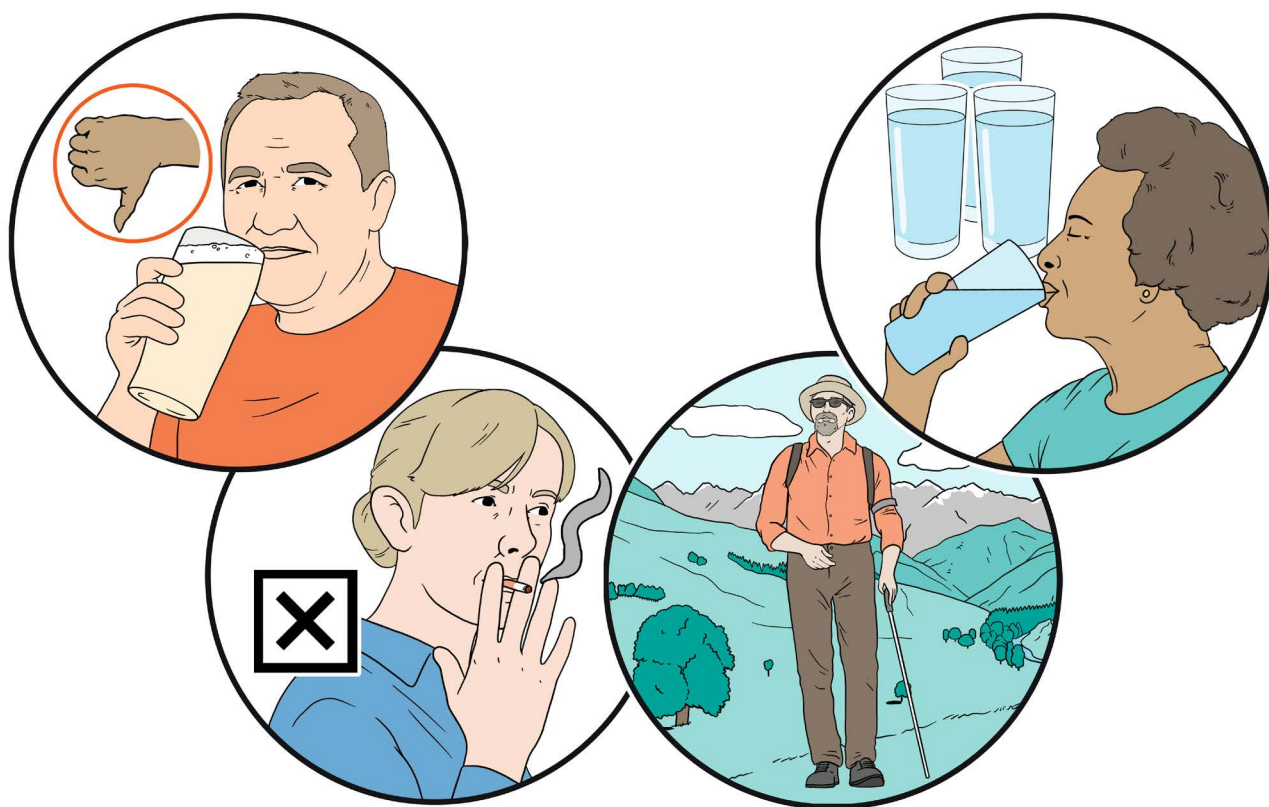


You can find more information about kidney friendly food and recipes on our website under Kidney Kitchen.



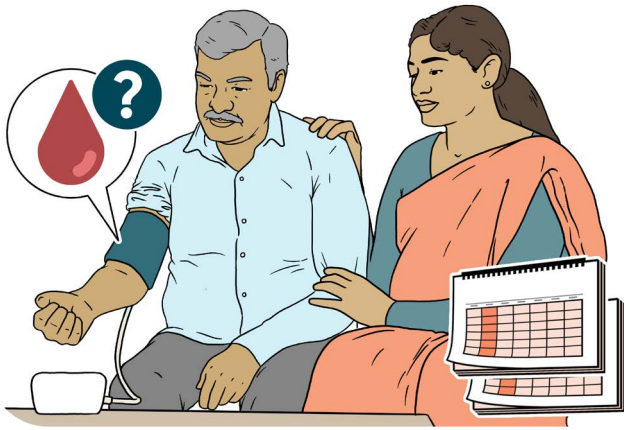
All of the recipes have detailed Food Facts that can help you know how many carbohydrates are in your meal.

How can I look after my kidneys if I have diabetes?

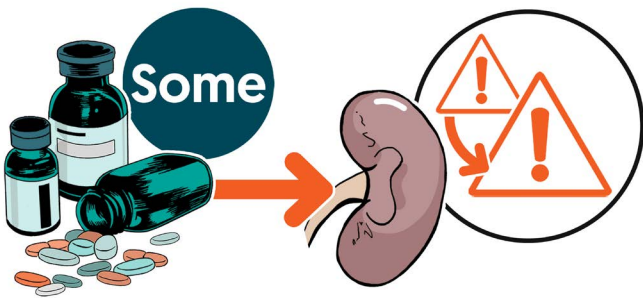


These are ways you can look after your kidneys:

- Stop drinking alcohol or drink less alcohol.
- If you are a smoker, stop smoking.
- Keep active and move as much as possible.
- Drink plenty of water and sugar free drinks.



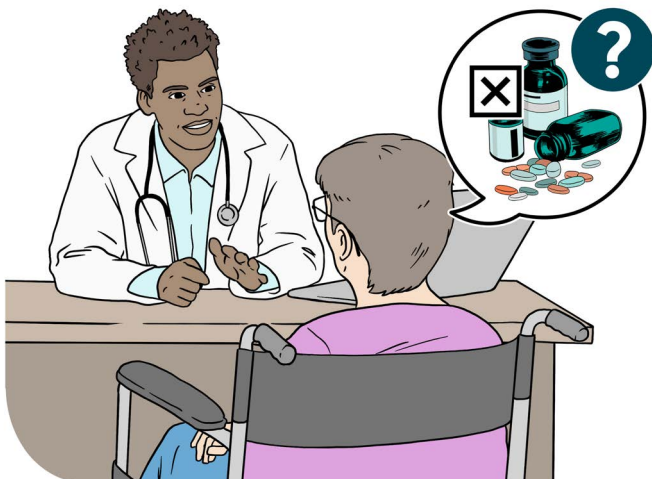
Check your blood pressure regularly. Your doctor can teach you how to check your blood pressure yourself at home.



Some medicines can make your kidney disease worse.



Tell your doctor and pharmacist that you have CKD and check that any medicine you are given is safe to take.



You should not stop taking any medicine you have been given by your doctor without talking to your doctor or a pharmacist first.

More information



Kidney Care UK has information about diabetes here:

www.kidneycareuk.org/diabetes



Kidney Kitchen is a collection of recipes for people living with all stages of kidney disease. Look through the free recipes and information about healthy eating here:

www.kidneykitchen.org



Diabetes UK has information about diabetes here:

www.diabetes.org.uk



The NHS has information about diabetes here:

www.nhs.uk/conditions/diabetes

This easy read booklet uses simple language and pictures to tell you about diabetes and chronic kidney disease (CKD). It has been made by Kidney Care UK, working with CHANGE.

CHANGE is a disability rights charity and accessible information expert.

Kidney Care UK is a support charity for kidney patients and their families. Contact us for advice and information on the free help that we offer.



Visit our website at: **kidneycareuk.org**



Email us at: **support@kidneycareuk.org**



Phone us at: **0808 801 00 00**



In partnership with



Images & Design © CHANGE

Publication date 02/2026 Review date 02/2029

© Kidney Care UK. Kidney Care UK is a charitable company limited by guarantee. Registered in England and Wales (1228114). A charity registered in England and Wales (270288) and Scotland (SC048198). KC86